

Winding lanes made of billions of stars form the colossal arms of the Whirlpool Galaxy, which sweeps through space like a sparkling cosmic wheel.

Bright regions are areas of starbirth

Giant galaxies are cannibals: they have grown large by **swallowing their neighbours**.

GALAXY SHAPES

Galaxies come in four main shapes. The most beautiful galaxies are the spirals, in which the stars lie in curved arms. In the barred spirals, the central stars form a short straight "bar". Elliptical galaxies are round balls of old stars, with little gas and dust. Shapeless galaxies are called irregular.



Spiral



Barred spiral



Elliptical



Irregular (detail)